

VEER

Around the House

Dinner, repairs, clutter, quotes, and the things that pile up.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Get dinner out of what you actually have, not what a recipe assumes you have.

Show it a photo of something broken and get somewhere useful.

Turn bad instructions into steps you can follow.

Declutter with a second opinion that has no feelings about your things.

Understand a quote before you agree to it.

Plan something with moving parts without holding it all in your head.

Keep a month of kitchen asks on the fridge door.

This is the least glamorous book in the series and probably the one you'll use most.

01

Dinner from what you actually have

Recipes are written backwards for real life. They begin with a list of things to go and buy; you begin with a fridge that already contains something.

So don't ask for a recipe. **Describe the fridge.**

The more honest the description the better this works, including the unglamorous parts — the half-used jar, the vegetable going soft, the thing you bought for a recipe you never made.

THE ONE THAT WORKS

I have chicken thighs, half a cauliflower, some rice, a lemon and the usual cupboard basics. About forty minutes. Two of us, one won't eat anything spicy. Give me three options.

Four things turn a vague answer into a usable one:

What you actually have. Including the awkward leftovers.

How long you've got. Twenty minutes and ninety minutes are different questions.

Who's eating. Numbers, and anything they won't touch.

How much effort you have in you. "I'm tired" is real information and changes the answer.

THE FOLLOW-UP WORTH HAVING

Ask *what could I add for under five pounds that would make this better?* You get a short shopping list instead of a full one, which is usually what the situation actually needs.

Try this now. Open the fridge, describe it honestly, and ask for three options.

02

The shopping list that matches the week

Most food waste comes from a list that doesn't match a week. You shop for the person you intend to be — someone who cooks properly on Wednesday — rather than the person who will actually get in at seven and be tired.

Describe the week, not the meals. Which nights are rushed, which are free, when you're out, who's in.

START HERE

Plan five dinners for two people. Monday and Thursday we're back late and need something in twenty minutes. Wednesday we're out. Saturday I'd enjoy cooking something slower. Then give me one shopping list grouped by supermarket aisle.

Ask for the list grouped by aisle. It sounds trivial and it halves the time in the shop.

Ask what overlaps. *Which ingredients get used in more than one of these?* is the question that reduces waste, because it steers toward meals that share things.

Say what you already have so it doesn't put it on the list again.

THE ONE THAT SAVES THE MOST

Ask it to plan around one ingredient you already have too much of. "I have a lot of potatoes and half a bag of spinach to use up" produces a genuinely different, cheaper week.

Try this now. Describe next week honestly — including the night you'll get takeaway — and ask for four dinners rather than seven.

03

What is this thing, and how do I fix it

The first time in this series you'll do something other than type: take a photo.

This is genuinely useful for household objects, because describing them is hard. You don't know what the part is called, which is exactly why you're stuck.

Take the photo, attach it, and describe the symptom. What it does, what it should do, what changed, and what you've already tried.

WITH A PHOTO ATTACHED

This is under my kitchen sink and there's a slow drip from the joint in the photo. It started about a week ago and gets worse when the washing machine runs. What am I looking at, and is this something I can fix myself?

Ask it to tell you whether to stop. The most valuable answer is sometimes *don't touch this, call someone.*

ALWAYS WORTH ADDING

Before you tell me how to fix it, tell me whether I should be doing this at all, and what would make it a job for a professional.

THE THREE WHERE YOU CALL SOMEONE

Gas. Electrics beyond changing a fuse or a bulb. Anything structural. A confident set of instructions is not the same as it being safe for you to follow, and this is a place where being wrong is expensive or dangerous.

Try this now. Photograph something in your house you've never understood and ask what it is.

04

Instructions you can actually follow

Flat-pack instructions, appliance manuals, and installation guides are frequently written by someone who already knows the answer. They skip steps, name parts you can't identify, and assume you can tell a wall plug from a wall anchor.

Paste them in and ask for the version you needed.

THE REWRITE

I'll paste in the instructions for assembling a chest of drawers. Turn them into numbered steps in plain English, tell me what tools I need before I start, and flag any step where it's easy to get it the wrong way round.

The "before I start" part matters more than the steps. Most household jobs go wrong because something was missing, not because a step was hard.

Three additions worth making:

What do I need before I start? Tools, parts, a second pair of hands, a clear floor.

Where do people usually get this wrong? It'll tell you, and it's usually the step you were about to rush.

How long will this actually take? Useful for deciding whether to begin at nine in the evening.

FOR ANYTHING WITH A MANUAL

Ask *how do I do the one thing I need* rather than reading the manual. "How do I set a delayed start on this washing machine" beats forty pages every time.

Try this now. Take the most confusing instructions in your house and ask for the numbered version.

05

Deciding what to keep

Decluttering stalls for a reason that has nothing to do with organisation. Every object carries a small decision with a feeling attached — money spent, a person who gave it, a version of yourself who might still need it.

What helps is a second opinion with no feelings about your things and endless patience for the same question.

Don't ask it to tell you what to throw away. It doesn't know what matters to you, and being told to bin something you love is a fast way to abandon the whole exercise.

Ask it to ask you questions instead.

THE ONE THAT UNSTICKS PEOPLE

I'm trying to clear out a spare room I've been avoiding for two years. Ask me questions about what's in there and how I've been thinking about it, until we've found a place to start. Don't give me a system.

FOR A SINGLE STUCK ITEM

I can't decide whether to keep something. Ask me four questions that would help me work out whether I actually want it.

THE ORDER THAT WORKS

Ask for the easiest category first, not the most important. Momentum decides whether a clear-out finishes, and nobody ever built momentum starting with a box of photographs.

Try this now. Name the room you've been avoiding and let it ask you questions.

06

Getting a quote you can understand

A quote for work on your house is a document designed by someone who does this every day, read by someone who does it once a decade. The gap is where the money goes.

Paste it in and ask what it doesn't say.

BEFORE YOU AGREE TO ANYTHING

I'll paste in a quote for replacing a bathroom. Explain what each line covers in plain English, tell me what's likely to be excluded, and give me the questions I should ask before agreeing.

The exclusions are the point. Most quote disputes are about work someone assumed was included.

Comparing two quotes is where this earns its keep. *Compare these two and tell me what's in one and not the other* surfaces the difference behind a price gap in seconds.

UNDERSTAND, DON'T DECIDE

This will help you read a quote and know what to ask. It cannot tell you whether a price is fair in your area, whether a trade is reputable, or whether the work is what your house needs. Get a second quote from a person, and check the trade properly.

Try this now. Find an old quote or bill and ask what it doesn't cover.

07

Planning something with moving parts

A birthday lunch for eleven. A bathroom refit around a working week. Christmas with two households and a dog. These fail not because any part is difficult but because you're holding all of it in your head at once.

Say all of it out loud, in whatever order it arrives, and ask for the order of operations.

THE BRAIN-DUMP

I'm hosting lunch for eleven people on Saturday. Two vegetarians, one who can't eat gluten, and my parents arriving the night before. I have one oven and a small kitchen. Tell me what to do when, working backwards from one o'clock.

"Working backwards from" is the phrase that does the work. It turns a list into a timetable, which is the thing you actually needed.

Two follow-ups worth having:

What can I do the day before? Almost always more than you think.

What's most likely to go wrong here, and what's the fallback? One oven is usually the answer, and knowing it in advance is what saves the day.

KEEP THE PLAN SOMEWHERE ELSE

Copy the timetable into a note or print it. A plan you have to go and find again is a plan you'll abandon halfway through Saturday morning.

Try this now. Take the next thing you're dreading organising and describe all of it in one messy paragraph.

08

The questions worth asking every week

Everything so far has been a problem you already had. This lesson is about the small recurring things that never become urgent enough to sit down and think about — and quietly cost you money and time for years.

A handful of questions, asked occasionally, pay for themselves:

Here's what we spent on food this month. What's the obvious thing to change?

What maintenance should I be doing at this time of year for a house like mine?

We keep running out of things. Help me work out what to keep stocked.

What's in this cupboard that I'm never going to use?

The value isn't the answer. It's that the question got asked at all — these are the things everyone intends to think about and nobody schedules.

THE ONE WORTH DOING TWICE A YEAR

"Here are the regular payments coming out of my account. Which of these are things people commonly forget they're still paying for?" It won't know your accounts, so you'll describe them — and describing them is most of the benefit.

Try this now. Pick one from the list above. Any one.

A month of kitchen asks

One a day, or one a week, or whenever the fridge defeats you.
Tear this out and stick it up.

What can I make with what's in the fridge tonight?

Give me three dinners under twenty minutes.

What can I do with the vegetables that are going soft?

Plan four dinners around what I already have.

What freezes well from tonight's cooking?

Give me a shopping list grouped by aisle for these five meals.

What's a cheaper version of the meal we always buy?

Turn these leftovers into something that isn't leftovers.

I have too many potatoes. Plan around that.

What can I batch-cook on Sunday for a busy week?

Give me one thing to cook that I've never made before.

What goes with the piece of meat I've defrosted?

Help me use up the half-empty jars in my fridge door.

What can I make that the children will actually eat?

Suggest a packed lunch that isn't a sandwich.

What should I do with the bread that's going stale?

Give me a meal for someone who isn't feeling well.

What can I cook in one pan tonight?

Help me plan a week of dinners under a set budget.

What's worth keeping in the freezer for emergencies?

When it goes wrong

"It suggested recipes with things I don't have." You described the meal you wanted rather than the food you own. List what's actually in there, including the odd items, and say *only these*.

"The instructions were wrong for my model." It doesn't know your appliance unless you name it. Give the make and model, or better, paste the manual text and ask about that.

"It told me to fix something I shouldn't have." It'll answer the question you asked. Ask the safety question first — Lesson 3 — and treat gas, electrics and anything structural as a call, not a job.

"The plan assumed I had more equipment than I do." Say what you have. "One oven, four rings, no microwave" changes everything.

"It gave me a system when I wanted a starting point." Ask it to ask you questions instead. That's Lesson 5, and it applies to most household planning.

"It was confident about a price." Prices are local and current, and this is exactly where confident answers are least reliable. Use it to understand what a quote covers, and get the number from people.

THE PATTERN HERE

Nearly every disappointment in this book comes from describing what you wanted instead of what you have. The fridge, the tools, the kitchen, the week — describe the real one.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other seven.

Describe what you actually have, not what you want.

The real fridge, with the wilting spinach. The real week, with the night you'll be too tired. The real kitchen, with one oven. The real quote, pasted in whole.

Every disappointing answer in this book comes from the gap between the situation you described and the one you're in. Close that gap and it stops giving you generic household advice and starts helping with Tuesday.

Do this next

Want your requests to land first time? → Asking Better

Questions — the four things that turn a generic answer into a useful one.

Cautious about what you're photographing and pasting? → Is

This Safe? — what it can and can't see, and the short list of things never to type in. Worth reading before you paste a quote with your address on it.

More ideas across the rest of life? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask

Claude — ten chapters, open at any page.

Messages you've been avoiding? → Letters, Emails, and

Awkward Messages — including the complaint to the tradesman who hasn't come back.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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